

Horror Campaigns Expansion

For Fate's Edge Tabletop RPG

Cosmic and Psychological Terror Framework

Designed for Campaigns of Any Length

Complete with Timer Generator System

"You want power? Fine. But don't come crying when the debt comes due."

Compiled from the personal archives of **Baron Quentin Asselin**

One of the Thirteen First Vampires, Keeper of the Chained Angel's oldest secrets

Transcribed and annotated by **Lerris Fenwood**, Fifth Son of Duke Braedon Fenwood

Tarlington, Year of the Broken Crown

A Letter to the Reader

You have found a thing that should not exist. I am Quentin Asselin, the first to drink from Malachai's wound. I was a paladin once. Now I am a monsterbut a monster who keeps records.

The Chained Angel speaks to me still. Not in words. In *interest*. Every century I return to Zahk'Kozahn to pay tribute. Every century I find something new in the ruins: a confession, a bargaining chip, a thread that leads to a deeper debt.

This expansion is not my work. It is a collection of fragments I have stolen, copied, or been given by those who owe me. The Grey Wanderer transcribed them. I only provide the shelf.

The first fragment is a confession. It was found in a leadlined box in a Daughter's safe house, hidden beneath a floorboard that had been nailed shut from below. The handwriting is Sister Aris's. The story is about a bargain made at the Well of Ichor, a hollowed child, and a plague that will come due in three generations.

You will read it and think you understand Malachai. You do not. You will think you understand the Cord. You do not.

But you will be closer to the edge. And the edge is where I live.

— Baron Quentin Asselin

Tarlington, under a sky that has forgotten its stars

Prologue: The Mirror and the Name

An account written by Lerris Fenwood, fifth son of Duke Braedon Fenwood, secret member of the Congregation of the Unmasking, and reluctant heir to a debt he never incurred.

It was with great trepidation that I stared into the mirror, awaiting a name to appear. My father, a man of many secrets, would be a prime target for the Unmasking, and I the ideal recipient of such a chore. And yet, as the fog from the ritual cleared, waning with the scent of incense and sweat, it was not my father's name which appeared.

Asselin was etched in the fog with a scribe's hand. A name I knew, but not from where. An old Vhasian name for I, an educated man, was as familiar with that language as I was my own. Still, as the fog of the mirror dissipated, I found the fog of my mind far more stubborn.

Then, as a bolt, it occurred to me. *Asselin*. A Baron of... either realm. A legend, almost. Rare at court. His barony nestled in the shadow of the Aelerian mountains, north of the Belworth's headwaters, north beyond memory. No crown sent for him, nor did any tax collector dare call him to account. It seemed that either realm was content with forgetting he existed. His rare appearances at court were an unwelcome reminder. The court preferred to forget him.

The mirror did not.

The Road North

The prospect of traveling to his realm was daunting. The roads north of the Belworth were twisted and cruel. I could only imagine how much worse they might become as I made my way. I am no adventurer, no hunter, and I knew not the way.

But it seems the Everflame provides, as my mother would say. A Tulkani woman of some prominence was camped outside Synod Square. I seized the chance to make her acquaintance. Dusana is a living legend. And I needed a legend to lead me to another.

"No," was her reply. Oddly short.

I pressed her. She offered to listen to a story and weigh its worth the traditional Tulkani refusal. In mild desperation, I reached back to home, to my brothers, to Markus. Some students' minds shatter when confronted with the University's secrets. My brother was such a case.

Another bolt struck. Divine providence, I thought bitterly. I told the story I had heard Markus ramble in his sleep.

Dusana's charming smile turned to a brief flash of horror, then a frown.

"We will take you," she said sadly. "And no more stories."

The road goes north, as Dusana says, and north we went. Across the Black River, past holdings more familiar to me than my breath, a brief stay with Seniro at Tarlington and north and north, to where we crossed the Belworth a dozen times a day. I truly knew not whether we were in Viterra or Vhasia, but the peasants spoke more and more the latter. The sun must wane here. I swear the pallor behind their eyes grew deeper with every mile.

At an old tollbooth, beaten and scarred by time and neglect, Dusana spoke the last of what might have been a gross of words on our long trek most of which seemed to be "Princling."

“We’re here,” she said. “We go no further.”

I unceremoniously left the troupe with a polite nod and a fond “Next time.” She responded in kind. The mist swallowed her wagons as they rumbled down the treacherous road.

And no sooner had the last of her wheels disappeared south into that fog than two riders appeared from the same fog from the north. Dressed in dark red and blue, their uniforms were as clean and sharp as their cheekbones. The rightmost rider sniffed.

“We take you,” the left one said, his Vhasian accent inflected by some quality I couldn’t quite name.

The right rider continued smoothly: “To the village, and then three nights’ ride.”

They knew I was here for the Baron.

I had not said a word.

The Baron’s Threshold

We walked through the courtyard, into the keep, and through a gallery of portrait each of a woman or a man, young, beautiful. Each bore a brass nameplate with a name scratched beyond legibility. The hand of the artwork was the same. And yet the paint faded and the frames aged as we proceeded.

The Baron awaited us in his parlor. He was a tall man, dark of hair and light of eye. His build was that of a warrior, refined by noble blood. His only mark was a small dueling scar on his left cheek. He dressed in fine white silk, emblazoned with a symbol I could not quite place.

“The Order of the Lost Angel,” the Baron stated flatly, his baritone voice echoing through the parlor as if he read my thoughts. “Welcome, young Lerris. My apologies I am preparing for a long voyage, and my time is limited.”

He gestured idly to two servants carrying a large chest. It sang of silver within as they jostled it.

“And since you reek of garlic and hedge knowledge, we need not stand on pretense. I am the Baron Asselin. I am ageless. Do you come as a hunter or a guest?”

Quite the greeting.

“I am Lerris,” I said hesitantly, before shaking my head. He knew that. He knew my name. “I come as a guest, my lord. Nothing more.”

“No need for such pleasantries. Your birth and station are far above mine, and you are welcome.” He gestured to his wiry servanta man of middling years with steel eyes. On his neck was the tattoo of the Chain-Lanterns, marking him as an inquisitor.

“However, I can smell the lust in you. The hunger.” The Baron continued, his voice soft. “I have smelled it a dozen dozen times.” He made a small gesture. Two servants bowed and receded behind the gallery.

“First, a bath. I don’t know what smells worse the garlic, or the hypocrisy of that iron emblem of the Everflame you wear over your heart.”

The Three Nights

The First Night: The Consort on the Ledger of Fear

She came at midnight a woman in riding leathers worn soft as old linen, her hair white with something other than age. Her eyes were the colour of old bruises, and she carried no weapon. She did not need one.

“The Baron sends his regards,” she said, leaning against the doorframe. “He says you are afraid. Good. Fear is the first toll. Pay it honestly, or it will compound.”

She stepped into the candlelight. Her shadow did not follow.

“You wish to hunt the things that hunt us. Very well. First lesson: **fear is not your enemy. It is your coal.** You stoke it, you burn it, you spend it.” She touched her chest where her heart should have been. “I was a hunter once. I hunted him. I tracked him for seven years across three empires. I burned through every comrade, every coin, every prayer. And when I finally stood before him, I had nothing left no steel, no silver, no witness. Only fear.”

“What did you do?”

“I spent it.” She smiled, and it did not reach her eyes. “I knelt. I offered him my terror in exchange for my life. He accepted. Now I am his most beloved consort.”

She turned to leave, then paused.

“The lesson, scholar: **you cannot destroy what you fear. You can only spend it.** The ledger of dread has seven columns, and each one must be balanced. You will learn to count them, or you will learn to kneel.”

Mechanical resonance: The **Dread Timer (10 segments)** tracks personal psychological deterioration. Each segment is a debt that can be prevented by spending Boon the coin of fear. The consort teaches that fear is a resource, not a flaw.

She left. At the threshold, she murmured, “After all, I am his most beloved consort.” The door closed. The room felt colder.

The Second Night: The Child on the Geometry of Madness

He came through the window a boy of sixteen, perhaps seventeen, with soft hands and a smile that showed too many teeth. He perched on the sill like a bird of prey, his silhouette wrong in ways I could not name.

“The Baron says you are curious,” the boy said. “Curiosity is a kind of hunger. The worst kind.”

“What do you hunger for?”

“I used to hunt his kind. I was very good at it.” He tilted his head. “I learned that the monsters are not the danger. The danger is what happens to the world when you look at them too long. **Reality begins to fracture.** The walls breathe. The corners stop meeting. You see colours that do not exist, and they see you back.”

He slid from the sill and walked a slow circle around me. His footsteps left no prints.

“I killed three of his children before I understood. With each death, the world tilted further. I began to speak in equations. I dreamed in geometries that had no name. The other hunters called

it madness. It was not madness. It was **comprehension without a vessel.**"

"How did you survive?"

"I stopped hunting. I knelt. Now I am his most beloved child, and the geometries sleep." He laughed a dry, brittle sound. "The lesson, scholar: **hunting breaks the world. Every truth you uncover is a crack in the mirror. Learn to count the cracks, or the cracks will count you.**"

Mechanical resonance: The **Reality Fracture Timer (12 segments)** tracks how much fundamental reality has been destabilized by cosmic contact. The child teaches that knowledge has a cost and that cost accrues whether you want it to or not.

He climbed back onto the sill. "After all, I am his most beloved child." Then he was gone, and the window was closed, and I could not remember opening it.

The Third Night: Michel on the Weight of Witness

Michel came at dawn. The Inquisitor. The valet. The one who had killed three of the Baron's children and been kept alive.

He did not smile. He did not posture. He simply stood in the centre of my chamber, hands folded behind his back, and waited.

"You have watched," he said. "You have listened. Now you must learn the last lesson: **hunting is not solitary. You need witnesses.**"

"Witnesses?"

"Every blow you strike, every truth you uncover, every monster you put down someone must see it. Not to applaud. To **hold the weight**. Without a witness, the horror does not die. It merely transfers. Into you."

He rolled up his sleeve. His forearm was a tapestry of scars, brands, cuts, the faint silver lines of old inquisitorial seals. But beneath them, almost invisible, was a **grey thread** wrapped around his wrist.

"I was an inquisitor of the Chain-Lanterns. I hunted his kind for thirty years. I was good at it. I had witnesses: clerks, notaries, acolytes who recorded every victory. But I did not understand that the witnesses were not for the hunted. They were for me. **To keep me whole.**"

He touched the thread.

"When I killed his third child, I had no witness. The child died alone, and I was alone, and something passed from her to me. A debt. An obligation. A **fracture in my own ledger**. The Baron found me three days later, weeping in a ditch, counting my own breaths."

"He did not kill you."

"No. He offered me a new role. A servant who records, not hunts. A witness who does not act." He looked at me with his steel eyes. "The lesson, scholar: **carry a witness. Keep a ledger. Record everything. When the horror comes for you, the record will hold what you cannot.**"

Mechanical resonance: The **Collective Sanity Timer (8 segments)** tracks group psychological effects. Michel teaches that solitary hunting leads to corruptionshared witness is a shield. The grey thread is the Cord's mark.

"After all," he said, "I am his most beloved servant."

He turned to leave.

"Michel," I called. "How do I ask him? For the secret?"

He paused. "Simply ask. He cannot refuse a polite request. It is his nature. The price, however..."

He shook his head. "The price is not yours to bear."

He faded into the grey light of dawn.

The Confrontation

I found the Baron in his study, seated before the portrait of the woman with the scratched nameplate. The silver chest sat at his feet, still singing.

“My lord,” I said. “I have kept your hospitality. I have listened to your hunters. Now I ask, as a guest: **give me the secret you hold.**”

The Baron grimaced. It was a small thing a tightening of the jaw, a flicker in the eyes but it was the first genuine emotion I had seen on his face.

“You ask for Malachai’s secrets,” he said quietly. “I hold them dear. They are the interest on a debt older than your bloodline.”

He glanced at Michel, who stood in the corner. The Inquisitor shrank actually *shrank*, shoulders drawing in, chin dropping. The Baron looked away, and Michel breathed again.

“But you have been polite,” the Baron continued. “You have played the guest, not the hunter. I cannot refuse a polite request. It is the only law I still honour.”

He gestured. Michel stepped forward and placed a leadlined box in my hands.

“The price is not yours to bear,” the Baron said. “But you will carry it nonetheless. That is the nature of secrets. They have weight. They accrue interest. And they are never, ever free.”

I clutched the box. “I will find a way to unmake you, Baron Asselin. I swear it.”

He sighed a long, weary exhalation, the sigh of a man who has heard such vows a hundred times.

“Yes,” he said. “I am sure you will. Escort for the scholar. See that he reaches the Black River by nightfall. And Michel”

“My lord?”

“Do not kill him. I have grown fond of his indignation.”

Michel led me out. The Baron did not watch us go. He was already studying the portrait of the woman with the scratched nameplate, his hand resting on the silver chest, his lips moving in a silent account.

The Ways Between

We did not ride south through Viterra. Michel took me not to the road, but to a door a door that had not been there a moment before, set into the bare stone of the mountain.

“The Ways Between,” he said. “The Baron’s gift. Or his insult. You will be across the Belworth by nightfall. The journey will take you one night. It will take something else from you as well. That is the toll.”

I stepped through.

I will not describe what I saw. The description would be a lie, and the lie would become a crack, and the crack would widen. I will only say that when I emerged on the far bank of the Black River, the sun was setting, and I was holding a leadlined box, and I had forgotten the colour of my mother’s eyes.

I did not open the box until I was safely across. The confession inside was not my burden. But I would carry it anyway.

The ledger does not close. It only passes to the next hand.

The Bargain at the Broken Well

A confession recovered from the ruins of a Daughter's safe house, written on the back of a grain manifest. The ink is lampblack and tears. The paper is scorched.

Under the lamp, bread and salt. The soup was free. The price was her.

I am Sister Aris, Keeper of the Door, and I am writing this because I will not remember it in the morning. The Cord takes memories as interest. But I have hidden this page in a lead-lined box, and I have paid a Trow to forget where. When the Cord finds it—and it will—I will already be ash.

My Hollowed has no name. I call him little one. He was weak. His mother was dead. A dark, uncertain life lay ahead. I held the cord tight. I did not unwrap it. The Cord demanded a breath or a death; I gave them a death.

He has been my witness for forty years. He does not eat. He does not sleep. He does not age. His eyes are sewn open with silver wire, and he watches every soul I tend, every death I harvest, every thread I tie. I have told myself he is not my son. I have told myself he is a tool.

I have lied.

The Cord does not forbid love. It forbids *attachment*. Love is a debt; attachment is a loan with no interest. The High Mother weaves attachment into the pattern, but She does not permit us to keep the thread for ourselves.

I have kept the thread.

The Road to Zahk'Kozahn

I fled the Cord at the dark of the moon. I took only my Hollowed, a skin of water, and a silver coin that had been pressed into a dead man's eye.

The cursed city is not on any map. You find it by walking toward the place where the stars forget their names. I walked for nine nights. Through desert. Through dreams. On the ninth, the walls rose from the dust—black basalt, slick with condensation that smelled of honey and copper.

The gates were open. The gates are always open.

Inside, the Worn shuffled past me—Shamblers, Screamers, Stalkers, and one Crackler who asked me for a name. I gave her the name of a Sister who had wronged me. She took it and laughed. Her joints snapped like dry twigs. “She will dream of drowning tonight,” the Crackler said. “That is the interest.”

I did not ask for the principal.

The Chained Angel

The ziggurat rose at the city's heart. I climbed. The steps were worn smooth by feet that had stopped bleeding centuries ago. At the top, a vaulted chamber lit by a single guttering candle.

And there She was.

Malachai hangs in chains of Aetherium—black iron that drinks light. Her wings are bound to the stone. Her mouth is sewn shut with silver wire. Her eyes are open. They are not angry. They are *patient*.

She spoke through a wound in Her throat, her voice the rasp of rust and honey.

"You have brought a Hollowed," she sighed. "And you wish to restore his heart."

I knelt. "I wish to raise him as my son. Not as a witness. Not as a tool. As a child."

Malachai's eyes flickered. The chains groaned.

"He was dead. He was killed with kindness long ago, letting the breath fade. The Cord accepted that death as payment for another. He is not yours. He is the Cord's."

"Then I will pay the Cord's price. Whatever it is."

"You do not understand, *little sister*. The Cord does not sell. It *transfers*. You cannot buy a Hollowed's heart from the High Mother. She does not own it. She merely holds it."

I did not understand. I still do not.

Malachai smiled, ash falling from her lips. Her chains rattled, the sound of bells and damnation.

"I can restore their heart. I can make their lungs fill with air, their blood move with warmth, their eyes close at night. They will grow. They will laugh. They will weep. They will be everything you lost when you held that cord."

"And the price?"

"A plague upon the Cord in three generations from this night. Not death—death is mercy. A *plague*. That's all you need know. The High Mother will forget a thread. A knot will loosen. A debt will be lost. The Cord will fray, just a little, just enough to let one soul slip free."

I thought of my Hollowed. I thought of his silver-wire eyes, his hands that never warmed, his heart that did not beat.

"One soul," I said. "You will let one soul slip free from the Cord?"

"One soul," Malachai agreed. "Not yours. Not theirs. But one."

I agreed.

The Restoration

Malachai reached through Her chains. Her fingers were long, cold, and smelled of the Well of Ichor. She touched my Hollowed's chest.

The grey thread that bound the child's heart unraveled. It did not fall—it *dissolved*, turning to ash that smelled of milk and iron. The ash swirled, then settled into the shape of a heart—small, pink, pulsing.

The Hollowed gasped.

Her eyes closed. When they opened, the silver wire was gone. Her eyes were brown—warm, bewildered, *alive*. And yet the way she tilted her head, the small furrow of her brow that was his. That was always his. And I loved her for it,

She looked at me. “Mama?” she said.

I wept. I had not wept in forty years. The Cord does not permit tears—tears are a debt unpaid. But I wept.

Malachai watched. Her smile was the smile of a creditor who has just written a new clause in fine print.

“The plague will come in three generations. You will not see it. But you will have raised a daughter. Is that not enough?”

I held my child. She was warm. She was real. I did not ask what the fine print said.

The Cord

We fled Zahk'Kozahn at dawn. My daughter—I named her Bryn, after my own mother, who had no name I ever spoke aloud—walked beside me. Her hand was small and warm.

We reached the Black River by nightfall. I built a fire. I poured two cups of tea.

As she drank, I saw it.

A grey thread, thin as a spider's silk, wrapped around her neck. It was not tight. It was *loose*—the way a Daughter ties her witness cord before a binding. The thread trailed behind her, disappearing into the darkness.

I reached for it. My fingers passed through.

“Mama?” she said. “What's wrong?”

I looked at her. Her eyes were warm. Her heart beat. She was alive.

But she was not free.

The Cord had not released her. Malachai had restored her heart, yes—but the Cord had never *owned* her heart. The Cord owned the *debt* that her death had paid. And that debt had not been erased. It had been *transferred*—from the dead twin to the living child.

Bryn is a Daughter of the Unbroken Cord. She always has been. She always will be.

I did not flee the Cord. I delivered my own Daughter into its keeping. My own *little sister*.

The Aftermath

I have raised her. She does not remember Zahk’Kozahn. She does not remember the Well of Ichor. She does not remember the day her heart began to beat.

She wears grey robes. She tends the dying. She collects debts. She is a good Daughter—efficient, precise, and cold.

Sometimes, when she sleeps, the grey thread around her neck glows faintly. I think the High Mother is whispering to her. I think Malachai is listening.

I have tried to cut the thread. I cannot. I have tried to tie it in knots. It loosens. I have tried to offer the Cord a substitute—a memory, a name, a year of my own life. The Cord does not accept substitutes.

The plague will come in three generations. I will not live to see it. But I have written this confession so that someone, somewhere, will know:

Malachai keeps Her bargains. The Cord does not forgive. And I—I am the woman who sold her daughter’s soul to buy her a heartbeat.

The soup is always free. The price never is.

— Sister Aris, Keeper of the Door, fleeing south
The ink is ash. The thread is grey. The child is Bryn.

Afterword: The Ledger Does Not Close

I closed the lead-lined box and sat in silence for a long time. The candle guttered. The room grew cold.

I understood now why the mirror had shown me Asselin's name instead of my father's. My father had not hidden a secret. He had inherited one. And now, so had I.

The price was not mine to bear.

But I would carry it anyway.

I folded the confession and placed it in my pocket. The Baron would have his three nights. I would have my answer. And somewhere, in the darkness north of the Belworth, a thread tightened.

The road goes south. The ink is fresh. The ninth cup remains un-poured.

— Lerris Fenwood, at the weighhouse in Tarlington, in the hour before the eighth bell

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1 Horror Campaigns Expansion Overview

1.1 Core Concept

Horror in Fate's Edge should create vulnerability and mounting dread while maintaining player agency and meaningful action. The unknown is more terrifying than the known.

1.2 Key Innovations

- Boon-based sanity management system
- Multi-layered campaign timers for escalating tension
- Breaking point mechanics for critical psychological moments
- Atmospheric investigation tools engaging all five senses
- Modular subgenre templates for quick campaign setup

1.3 Target Themes

- Isolation and vulnerability
- Unknown threats beyond comprehension
- Psychological decay and mental deterioration
- Escalating tension throughout campaigns
- Moral ambiguity and difficult choices
- Cosmic insignificance and existential dread

1.4 Mechanical Focus

- Resource management through Boon economy
- Investigative procedures with sanity costs
- Environmental hazards and reality distortions
- Collective psychological effects
- Multi-timer tension building systems

2 Safety and Consent

Horror is as much about trust as fear. Use tools that suit your table; this book assumes some combination of lines-and-veils, X-card, open door, and debrief.

2.1 Session Zero Safety Pass

Before characters exist, the table should:

- List **lines** (no-go content), **veils** (fade-to-black), and **preferences** (desired or avoided motifs).
- Choose a quick signal for **pause** and **rewind** (e.g., “*cut*,” “*hold*,” or a hand sign).

- Decide how to **check in** mid-session (traffic light, stars and wishes, or one-word mood check).
- Name **anchors** for each PC (a person, a place, and an object that stabilize them).

2.2 On-Table Procedures

During play:

- The GM **front-loads content warnings** before potentially graphic scenes.
- Anyone may call for a **tone shift** or **content veil** without explanation.
- After heavy scenes, run a **breather**: water, deep breaths, small talk—then confirm consent to continue.
- Close with a short **debrief**: what worked, what to avoid next time, what to emphasize.

2.3 Hard Stops

If someone says stop, you stop. Take a break, close the session, or pivot scenes. Content is never worth breaking trust.

3 Core Mechanical Framework

3.1 Dread Timer - Sanity as Resource Management

The signature system replaces traditional sanity points with a Boon-based approach where players must spend resources to prevent psychological deterioration.

Purpose and Integration

This system connects to the existing Boon economy while adding horror-specific tension through the multi-timer system. Players choose when to spend Boons to prevent Dread advancement, creating meaningful decisions about risk versus stability.

Sample Uses:

1. Witnessing a Mist Wraith causes +1 segment advancement - player spends 1 Boon to prevent it
2. Learning cosmic truth about reality triggers +3 segments - player must spend 3 Boons or face severe psychological effects
3. Entity observation advances Dread by 2 segments - party must collectively decide how to manage limited Boon resources

3.2 Resource Management - Boons as Sanity Currency

Acquisition Methods:

- Failing rolls (standard Boon economy)
- Bond-driven actions with intricate descriptions
- GM discretion for thematic play

- Session participation and milestone achievements

Spending Options:

- Preventing Dread Timer advancement
- Rerolling dice for critical actions
- Activating protective assets and items
- Converting to XP (max 2 per session)

Narrative Weight: Players must choose between immediate tactical advantages and long-term psychological stability.

3.3 Risk/Reward Balance

Safe Choices:

- Surface-level investigation with minimal horror exposure
- Conservative approach with reduced Boon economy (-1 die penalties)
- Avoiding direct confrontation with unknown threats

Controlled Choices:

- Deep investigation with significant horror exposure
- Direct engagement with incomprehensible entities
- Pursuing forbidden knowledge at personal cost
- +1-3 Dread segments, potential breaking points

Failure States:

- Dread Timer fills completely
- Character becomes Broken - out of control, hostile to allies
- Permanent psychological damage requiring intervention
- Transformation into agent of horror

4 Campaign Timer Framework

4.1 Primary Clock: Dread Timer (10 segments)

Psychological deterioration and mounting horror affecting individual characters.

Dread Clock	Psychological deterioration and mounting horror
Segments	• • • • • • • • • • 0/10

Advancement Triggers:

- Witnessing death or violence: +1 segment (prevent with 1 Boon)

- Encountering the unknown: +1 segment (prevent with 1 Boon)
- Personal failure leading to harm: +1 segment (prevent with 1 Boon)
- Direct threat to sanity/morality: +2 segments (prevent with 2 Boons)
- Major revelation about the horror: +2 segments (prevent with 2 Boons)
- Companion/friend harmed or lost: +3 segments (prevent with 3 Boons)

Consequences when filled: Character becomes Broken - out of control, may become hostile to allies, permanent psychological damage, requires major intervention to recover.

4.2 Secondary Timers

4.2.1 Reality Fracture Timer (12 segments)

How much fundamental laws of reality have been altered by cosmic influence.

Reality Clock	Fracture	Fundamental laws of reality becoming unreliable
Segments		• • • • • • • • • • 0/12

Advancement Triggers:

- Impossible phenomena observed: +1 segment per day
- Dimensional mathematics researched: +2 segments
- PCs directly perceive alien geometry: +3 segments
- Local reality becomes unstable: +2 segments per incident
- Ancient experiments disturbed: +3 segments

Consequences when filled: Barriers between dimensions collapse completely; entity manifests fully in normal space.

4.2.2 Collective Sanity Timer (8 segments)

How much the party and observers are affected by cosmic horror.

Collective Clock	Sanity	Group psychological effects and shared hallucinations
Segments		• • • • • • • 0/8

Advancement Triggers:

- Reality Fracture Timer advances: +1 segment
- Direct observation of alien entities: +2 segments each
- Comprehension of higher-dimensional concepts: +2 segments

- Witnessing impossible geometric shapes: +1 segment each
- Temporal anomalies experienced: +1 segment per hour

Consequences when filled: Shared hallucinations become reality; party exists partially outside normal space.

4.2.3 Existential Threat Timer (15 segments)

How close cosmic entity is to full manifestation in our reality.

Existential Threat Clock	Cosmic entity approaching full manifestation
Segments	• • • • • • • • • • • • • • • 0/15

Advancement Triggers:

- Reality Fracture reaches 6 segments: +2 segments
- Collective Sanity reaches 6 segments: +3 segments
- PCs attempt to communicate with alien intelligence: +3 segments
- Dimensional barriers weakened further: +2 segments
- Ancient safeguards fail: +4 segments

Consequences when filled: Entity begins reshaping local reality according to alien logic.

4.3 Timer Interaction

Reality Fracture drives other timers; as it advances, Collective Sanity and Existential Threat accelerate. High Collective Sanity makes Reality Fracture advance faster as perception warps reality.

5 Character Integration System

5.1 Thematic Character Options

5.1.1 Investigator Archetypes

Scholar/Researcher:

- Recognizes ancient symbols, understands cosmic principles (+1 Lore)
- Risks comprehension breaking points from forbidden knowledge
- Vulnerable to reality distortion when theories proven wrong

Veteran/Survivor:

- Resistant to fear (-1 Dread advancement from combat exposure)
- Vulnerable to reality distortions that break tactical understanding
- Experienced with supernatural threats but may be overconfident

Psychic/Sensitive:

- Can perceive hidden truths (+1 Perception for supernatural detection)
- Suffers +1 Dread from all supernatural exposure
- May become overwhelmed by too much psychic input

Skeptic/Rationalist:

- Immune to some psychological effects through rational disbelief
- Suffers severe penalties (-2 dice) when forced to accept impossibility
- May become dangerously obsessed with proving rational explanations

5.2 Background Integration

Traumatized Past:

- Start with 1 segment on Dread Clock
- Gain +1 die to resist similar future exposures
- May have flashbacks triggered by related stimuli

Occult Knowledge:

- Access to forbidden lore (Wits + Lore, DV 3)
- Each use advances Dread by 1 and generates 1 SB
- May attract unwanted supernatural attention

Military Training:

- +1 die to combat supernatural threats
- -1 die to social interactions due to paranoia
- May resort to violence when other options fail

Religious Faith:

- Immunity to fear effects from traditional horror
- Vulnerable to anti-holy entities and corrupted faith
- May struggle with moral compromises required for survival

5.3 Mechanical Hooks

5.3.1 Breaking Points

Specific triggers that force immediate Dread advancement unless resisted:

- **Witnessing Corruption:** Seeing friend/ally become corrupted (+2 Dread)
- **Personal Loss:** Losing something precious (+3 Dread)
- **Moral Compromise:** Acting against core beliefs (+2 Dread)
- **Incomprehensible Truth:** Understanding reality-breaking fact (+3 Dread)

Resistance Options:

- Spend 2 Boons to prevent advancement
- Spirit + Resolve roll (DV 5) with narrative justification
- Relevant Talents or Backgrounds provide resistance

5.3.2 Corruption Track

Physical/mental changes that occur at high Dread levels:

- 7+ Dread: Speaking in equations, seeing geometric patterns
- 8+ Dread: Attraction to dark spaces, partial dimensional existence
- 9+ Dread: Unreliable narrator, shared hallucinations become real
- 10+ Dread: Broken - permanent transformation, hostile to allies

5.3.3 Collective Insanity

Party average Dread affects everyone's perception of reality:

- Average 5+: Shared hallucinations, impossible events become real
- Average 7+: Geometric spaces shift based on group consensus
- Average 9+: Group paranoia and infighting, -2 dice to cooperation

6 Quick Setup Protocol

6.1 30-Minute Campaign Launch

Character Preparation:

- Use pre-generated Tier II characters or build using 32 XP with horror-themed backgrounds
- Ensure party has mix of investigative, combat, and social capabilities
- Assign relevant Talents for horror engagement (Lorekeeper, Backlash Soothing)

Core Conflict Establishment:

1. PCs encounter impossible phenomena that challenge reality/f sanity
2. Threat appears to be beyond normal comprehension
3. Stakes involve personal survival and broader existential implications

Opening Scene Hook:

- Familiar environment becomes alien
- Impossible constellations in night sky
- Architecture defying geometric principles
- Whispers in familiar voices of missing people

Primary Campaign Clock:

- Dread Timer (10 segments) as personal threat

- 2-3 supporting timers based on horror subgenre
- Start all timers at 1-2 segments for immediate tension

Key Mechanical Tutorial:

- Introduce Dread Timer management through first horror encounter
- Demonstrate breaking point resistance with meaningful choice
- Show resource management between investigation and self-preservation

6.2 Scaling Options

6.2.1 Short Form (1-2 sessions)

- Single timer (Dread 8 segments) for focused threat
- Simplified breaking points with clear resistance options
- Limited corruption effects, mostly psychological
- Resolution focused on immediate survival/containment

6.2.2 Standard Form (3-5 sessions)

- Full 4-timer system with complex interactions
- Multiple breaking point types and resistance methods
- Progressive corruption with permanent character changes
- Multiple resolution paths with different consequences

6.2.3 Extended Form (6+ sessions)

- Campaign-level consequences affecting world/region
- Permanent reality alterations from filled timers
- Character retirement/retcon options for broken PCs
- Sequel hooks and ongoing cosmic threat elements

7 Environmental and Narrative Mechanics

7.1 Setting-Driven Mechanics

7.1.1 Reality Distortion Zones

Areas where physics/geometric principles become unreliable:

- Modifiers: -1 Investigation, +1 SB generation
- Spatial navigation requires Wits + Survival (DV 3-4)
- May generate 2 SB for time loops or dimensional folds

Player Interaction:

- Can attempt stabilization with Arcana rolls but at cost of advancing timers

- Accepting impossibility grants DV 1 on next navigation roll
- Mathematical instruments may provide +1 die to related rolls

7.1.2 Temporal Anomalies

Time flows differently or loops in specific areas:

- +1 Investigation for pattern recognition
- Generates 2 SB for time loops and paradoxes
- May cause characters to become “unstuck” in time

Effects:

- Unreliable narrators who remember multiple timeline branches
- Repeating conversations with slight variations
- Causality breaking down - effects preceding causes

7.2 Atmosphere Tools

7.2.1 Sensory Engagement

Sound:

- Whispers that shouldn't be there
- Silence that presses against eardrums
- Geometric harmonies that hurt to hear
- Temporal echoes of future conversations

Sight:

- Impossible shadows with their own movement
- Colors that shouldn't exist in natural spectrum
- Peripheral movement that vanishes when directly observed
- Geometric shapes existing in more than three dimensions

Touch:

- Surfaces that breathe and pulse rhythmically
- Temperatures that shift without environmental cause
- Textures that change under fingers when not observed
- Gravity flowing in impossible directions

Smell:

- Scents of places that never existed
- Odors of concepts made physical (fear, time, mathematics)
- Aromas that trigger false memories of impossible events

- Fragrances that seem to move independently of air currents

Taste:

- Metallic fear on tongue during supernatural encounters
- The flavor of wrongness when reality distorts
- Aftertastes of cosmic truths that linger for hours
- Tastes that seem to exist in multiple dimensions simultaneously

7.3 Narrative Structure

7.3.1 Scene Types

Investigation:

- Gathering clues while managing sanity/resource costs
- Wits + Investigation or Lore rolls with potential Dread advancement
- May generate SB for reality distortions or entity attention

Confrontation:

- Direct engagement with horror elements
- Combat modified by psychological state (-1 die at 5+ Dread)
- Breaking point triggers for moral/psychological challenges

Breaking Point:

- Critical moments testing psychological limits
- Immediate Dread advancement unless resisted
- May result in permanent character changes or retirement

Revelation:

- Discovery of cosmic truths with severe consequences
- Comprehension breaking points risking +3 Dread advancement
- May unlock new investigative paths or resolution options

7.3.2 Pacing Markers

Sessions 1-2:

- Local anomalies and minor reality distortions
- Introduction to threat without full comprehension
- Personal stakes established through connections to location/missing persons

Sessions 3-4:

- Pattern recognition revealing deeper conspiracy
- First direct contact with entities or incomprehensible concepts

- Comprehension breaking points as forbidden knowledge accessed

Sessions 5+:

- Full revelation of cosmic threat and implications
- Existential stakes becoming clear to all characters
- Resolution with universal consequences and permanent changes

7.3.3 Resolution Formats

Success States:

- **The Sacrifice:** Permanently contain entity through personal cost (15-18 XP)
- **The Investigation:** Fully understand and banish threat (18-20 XP)
- **The Containment:** Seal threat temporarily (12-15 XP)

Failure States:

- **The Corruption:** Become agent of horror (8-10 XP, character transformation)
- **The Breaking:** Succumb to madness (0-5 XP, character retirement)
- **The Ignorance:** Flee without understanding (10-12 XP, ongoing campaign thread)

Partial Success:

- **The Bargain:** Negotiate with entity for limited influence (12-15 XP, ongoing responsibilities)
- **The Transformation:** Partial corruption with retained agency (15-17 XP, character change)

Pyrrhic Victory:

- **The Price:** Victory achieved but at devastating cost to world/self (18-20 XP, major consequences)

8 GM Toolkit

8.1 Session Preparation Checklist

- Prepare key horror draws for session (impossible phenomena, entity manifestations, breaking point triggers)
- Timer tracking sheets with trigger conditions clearly marked
- Key NPC motivations, secrets, and potential corruption states
- Environmental complication cards for reality distortions
- Breaking point scenarios and resistance options for each PC
- Index cards with sensory descriptions for atmosphere building
- SB spending options tied to current horror elements

8.2 Complication Generator

8.2.1 Mild (1 SB)

- Path shows reflection of alternate self
- Familiar voice whispers from darkness
- Waymark points wrong direction
- Unsettling geometric patterns in peripheral vision
- Temperature drop without environmental cause

8.2.2 Moderate (2 SB)

- Reality thins - see dreams of others
- Temporal loop shows funeral preparations
- Memory absorption begins during investigation
- Shadows move independently of light sources
- Mathematical equations appear spontaneously in environment

8.2.3 Serious (3 SB)

- Dimensional mathematics become comprehensible (advance Dread by 2)
- Entity's patterns appear in environment
- Trusted companion shows signs of possession
- Gravity flows in impossible directions
- Time begins moving backward in specific area

8.2.4 Major (4+ SB)

- Entity manifests partially through resonance
- Reality becomes unstable in area
- Previous choice comes back to haunt PCs
- Multiple timeline branches become visible simultaneously
- Fundamental law of physics ceases to be reliable

8.3 Player Agency Reminders

Handling Unexpected Approaches:

- Embrace creativity but ensure horror elements still manifest
- Adapt entity responses to match player innovations
- Allow success but with horror-themed consequences
- Provide multiple valid paths to objectives

When to Push Back:

- Only when player choices would break core horror themes
- When actions would eliminate all tension or challenge
- When safety/pacing requires narrative redirection
- When mechanical balance needs preservation

Maintaining Tension:

- Use timer advancement and breaking points rather than adversarial GMing
- Provide meaningful choices with real consequences
- Balance hope and despair throughout campaign
- Let player decisions drive horror escalation

9 Experience and Resolution Systems

9.1 Experience Awards

Participation:

- +2 XP per session attendance
- +1 XP for meaningful horror engagement
- +1 XP for contributing to atmospheric tension

Thematic Play:

- +1-2 XP for meaningful horror engagement
- +1 XP for playing character's psychological flaws
- +2 XP for embracing breaking point consequences

Risk Taking:

- +1-3 XP for choosing dangerous investigative paths
- +2 XP for resisting breaking points at cost
- +1 XP for pursuing forbidden knowledge

Breaking Point Resistance:

- +2 XP for successfully resisting major psychological trauma
- +1 XP for partial resistance with consequences
- +3 XP for transforming breaking point into character growth

Narrative Contribution:

- +1-2 XP for creating memorable horror moments
- +1 XP for contributing to group survival
- +2 XP for defining campaign's central horror theme

10 Modular Design Elements

10.1 Plug-and-Play Components

Dread Timer System:

- Works independently in any horror scenario
- Scalable segment counts for different campaign lengths
- Compatible with existing Boon economy

Breaking Point Mechanics:

- Can enhance investigation or combat encounters
- Adaptable to different horror subgenres
- Integrates with character backgrounds and talents

Reality Distortion Zones:

- Can be added to any location
- Modular effects based on campaign tone
- Compatible with existing environmental hazards

Collective Sanity Effects:

- Work in any group-based horror campaign
- Scale with party size and composition
- Create shared consequences for individual actions

10.2 Cross-Expansion Compatibility

Noir Expansion:

- Psychological breaking points enhance moral ambiguity
- Collective sanity effects mirror group paranoia
- Reality distortion zones complement urban atmosphere

Cyberpunk Expansion:

- Technological horror through reality distortion
- Corporate conspiracy elements in cosmic threats
- Character corruption parallels cybernetic augmentation

Fantasy Expansion:

- Cosmic entities as ancient gods/demons
- Magical research risks mirror forbidden knowledge
- Reality fracture effects enhance spell backlash

10.3 Power Scaling

Lower Tiers (Rookie/Seasoned):

- Reduced SB generation from horror encounters
- Simpler reality distortions with clear navigation
- Fewer breaking point triggers and easier resistance
- More recovery options for Dread advancement

Higher Tiers (Veteran/Paragon):

- Increased cosmic comprehension risks (+3 Dread for understanding)
- More severe reality alterations affecting core mechanics
- Complex entity interactions requiring specialized knowledge
- Harsher consequences for filled timers and broken characters

New Players:

- Streamlined timer system with fewer secondary timers
- More recovery options and safety mechanisms
- Clearer breaking point resistance paths
- Reduced penalties for high Dread states

Experienced Players:

- Additional complications and harsher consequences
- Fewer safety mechanisms and more permanent effects
- Complex moral choices with no clear right answers
- Integration with existing campaign threads and consequences

11 Horror Deck Generators

11.1 Cosmic Horror Generator

Theme: Reality-breaking threats that challenge understanding of existence itself

Special Mechanics:

- Any Ace adds a fundamental law of reality that becomes unreliable
- Face cards (J/Q/K) represent cosmic entities or phenomena beyond normal comprehension
- Black suits (♠, ♣): Physical reality distortions, existential threats
- Red suits (♥, ♦): Psychological/cosmic influence, forbidden knowledge

11.1.1 Spades — Places (impossible locations, reality-warped sites)

- 2. Observatory with a telescope that shows stars that shouldn't exist
- 3. Library where books rewrite themselves when read

- 4. Laboratory where the walls breathe and mathematical equations drip like liquid
- 5. Ancient vault with doors that open to different dimensions
- 6. Tower that exists in multiple time periods simultaneously
- 7. Cave system where gravity flows in impossible directions
- 8. Room where the corners don't meet and shadows have shadows
- 9. Mirror maze that reflects possible futures instead of present reality
- 10. Garden where plants grow in geometric patterns that hurt to perceive
- J. Research station experiencing temporal anomalies and dimensional bleeds
- Q. Ancient temple built according to alien geometry that shouldn't be physically possible
- K. Black monolith that exists partially outside normal space-time
- A. Location where a fundamental law of physics (time, gravity, causality) no longer applies

11.1.2 Hearts — Entities & Factions (cosmic beings, affected people)

- 2. Researcher who speaks only in mathematical equations
- 3. Astronomer who can see the approach of something from beyond
- 4. Mathematician whose calculations predict reality fractures
- 5. Entity that exists as pure geometric impossibility
- 6. Being from outside normal space-time seeking understanding
- 7. Collective consciousness of a species that transcended physical form
- 8. Fragment of a dead god that remembers when reality was different
- 9. Scientist whose mind has been rewritten by cosmic influence
- 10. Cultist who worships mathematical perfection and cosmic order
- J. Ancient Aeler philosopher who opened doors that should have remained closed
- Q. Cosmic entity that communicates through stellar movements and impossible geometry
- K. Being that exists simultaneously in all possible dimensions
- A. Intelligence that predates the current configuration of reality itself

11.1.3 Clubs — Threats & Complications (reality distortions, existential dread)

- 2. Stars moving in patterns that violate known astronomical laws
- 3. Mathematical proof that shows reality is fundamentally inconsistent
- 4. Temporal loop where the same conversation repeats with slight variations
- 5. Geometric shapes that exist in more than three dimensions becoming visible
- 6. Fundamental constant of physics beginning to shift and change
- 7. Memory of events that never happened becoming more real than actual history

- 8. Observer effect causing reality to change based on perception
- 9. Causality breaking down—effects preceding their causes
- 10. Consciousness beginning to exist in multiple states simultaneously
- J. Local reality becoming unstable and fragmenting into possibility storms
- Q. Dimensions beginning to bleed into each other, mixing incompatible laws
- K. The universe approaching a mathematical proof of its own non-existence
- A. A fundamental aspect of existence (time, space, identity) ceasing to be reliable

11.1.4 Diamonds — Revelations & Resources (forbidden knowledge, cosmic tools)

- 2. Star charts showing constellations from impossible angles
- 3. Mathematical formula that describes the shape of space-time itself
- 4. Instrument that can detect fluctuations in the fundamental constants
- 5. Tome written in a language that predates human civilization by eons
- 6. Crystal that stores memories from alternate versions of reality
- 7. Equation that can temporarily stabilize dimensional barriers
- 8. Observatory equipment calibrated to detect entities from outside normal space
- 9. Protective ward that maintains local reality coherence for a limited time
- 10. Research notes detailing experiments into forbidden dimensions
- J. Key to an ancient vault containing Aeler research into reality structure
- Q. Device that can briefly open controlled portals to adjacent dimensions
- K. Formula for creating paradoxes that can trap cosmic entities
- A. Knowledge of how to permanently seal breaches in dimensional barriers

Quick Use Notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage
- Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10)
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (knowledge/tools) that change position rather than call for a roll
- If any Ace appears, add a fundamental law of reality that becomes unreliable (time flows backward, gravity weakens, etc.)
- Face cards represent cosmic entities or phenomena beyond normal comprehension

Using the Cosmic Horror Generator

Standalone Campaign Use: When using the Cosmic Horror generator on its own, focus

on reality-breaking threats that challenge the fundamental nature of existence. The generator provides a complete framework for campaigns where the PCs face threats beyond normal comprehension.

Key Considerations:

- **Scale:** Cosmic horror operates on a universal or existential scale rather than personal threats
- **Comprehension:** Understanding the threat may be as dangerous as ignoring it
- **Permanence:** Changes to reality may be irreversible
- **Isolation:** The PCs may be among the few who perceive the true threat

Standalone Setup:

1. Draw the full seed (Spade, Heart, Club, Diamond) to establish the cosmic threat
2. Note any Aces for fundamental reality changes
3. Use Face cards to identify cosmic entities involved
4. Set primary timer based on highest rank
5. Establish 2-3 supporting timers (Reality Fracture, Collective Sanity, Existential Threat)

Mixed Generator Use: The Cosmic Horror generator excels at adding existential weight to other campaign types. Mix it with regional generators to create campaigns where local threats have cosmic implications.

Common Mixing Strategies:**With Mistlands:**

- Use Mistlands Spades/Clubs for atmospheric horror
- Use Cosmic Hearts/Diamonds for the underlying threat
- Result: Ancient entities sleeping beneath the mist, awakened by reality fractures

With Acasia:

- Use Acasia Spades/Clubs for cursed locations and social pressure
- Use Cosmic Hearts/Diamonds for the true threat behind local disturbances
- Result: Merchant houses unknowingly trafficking in reality-distorting artifacts

With Aeler:

- Use Aeler Spades/Clubs for underground locations and ancient dangers
- Use Cosmic Hearts/Diamonds for the vault-dwelling entities
- Result: Dwarven experiments that opened doors to impossible dimensions

With Valewood:

- Use Valewood Spades/Clubs for phasing ruins and imperial residue
- Use Cosmic Hearts/Diamonds for the entities behind the empire's fall

- Result: The empire fell not to war, but to reality-altering influence

Mixing Procedure:

1. Draw 2-3 cards from base generator (location, local actor, local pressure)
2. Draw 1-2 cards from Cosmic Horror generator (cosmic entity, reality threat)
3. Blend elements to create a threat that feels both local and universal
4. Use base generator's timer size, modified by cosmic elements
5. Add 1-2 cosmic-themed supporting timers to base campaign timers

Campaign Integration Tips:

Gradual Revelation: Start with local/normal threats, gradually revealing cosmic implications. Players are more invested when they discover their small problem is part of a universal threat.

Personal Stakes: Even cosmic threats need personal connections. Tie the existential danger to characters' backgrounds, goals, or loved ones.

Escalation Patterns:

- Sessions 1-2: Local anomalies, minor reality distortions
- Sessions 3-4: Pattern recognition, first contact with cosmic entities
- Sessions 5-6: Full revelation, existential stakes become clear
- Final Session: Resolution with universal consequences

Reality as Character: Treat the laws of physics and fundamental reality as active elements that can shift, change, and react to player actions. When players solve problems, let reality itself respond.

Knowledge Management: Forbidden knowledge should be both valuable and dangerous. Create systems where learning the truth advances both understanding and threat levels.

Mixed Deck Campaign: "The Whispering Depths" (Mistlands + Cosmic Horror)

Campaign Setup: Mixing the Mistlands generator with Cosmic Horror creates a campaign where ancient entities sleeping beneath the fog have begun to awaken as reality barriers weaken.

Drawn Elements:

- Mistlands Spade (7 - Pall Watch-tower on piles above the mire)
- Cosmic Horror Heart (Q - Cosmic entity that communicates through stellar movements)
- Mistlands Club (9 - Bell-line failure on the levee; a wraith steps across like it owns the road)
- Cosmic Horror Diamond (8 - Instrument that can detect fluctuations in the fundamental constants)

Timer Size: 9 (Queen) = 8-segment primary timer

Campaign Hook: The Pall Watch-tower, a key defensive position in the Mistlands, has begun experiencing temporal anomalies. Guards report that the bell-line failures don't follow

normal patterns—instead, the bells ring in mathematical sequences that correspond to stellar movements visible only through the tower’s ancient spyglass. Something from beyond normal space is using the weakened barriers between dimensions to influence the physical world, and the bell-code system that once kept the Mistlands safe is now serving as a communication channel for entities that predate human civilization.

Key NPCs:

- Bell-Warden Thorne: Paranoid keeper who first noticed the anomalous bell patterns
- Astronomer-Liaison Mara: Assigned to interpret the stellar correlations, slowly losing sanity
- The Deep Listener: Cosmic entity that exists partially in our dimension, communicating through bell harmonics

Campaign Timers:

- Bell-Line Corruption (8): How much the communication system has been compromised
- Reality Fracture (10): Local weakening of dimensional barriers
- Collective Sanity (8): Mental stability of the watch-tower garrison

Resolution Paths:

- Seal the dimensional breach using the stellar-aligned bell-code in reverse
- Negotiate with the entity to establish a controlled communication channel
- Destroy the watch-tower to sever the connection, sacrificing the region’s defense
- Allow the entity full access to our reality in exchange for protection from other cosmic threats

Horror Elements:

- The bells ring in patterns that hurt to hear directly
- Guards begin aging rapidly during their watches
- Shadows cast by the tower show events from impossible futures
- The entity’s influence causes time to loop in 8-hour cycles

12 Horror Campaign Timers Generator

12.1 Core Concept

The Horror Campaign Timers Generator creates thematically appropriate multi-timer systems for any horror scenario, providing escalating tension and meaningful consequences that drive narrative forward while maintaining mechanical coherence.

12.2 Generator Structure

Primary Timer - Dread Timer (10 segments)

- Always represents psychological deterioration and mounting horror
- Universal across all horror subgenres
- Personal consequences for each character

Secondary Timers (2-3 timers, 8-15 segments)

- Thematic timers that reflect specific horror elements
- Drive broader consequences beyond individual characters
- Create multi-layered tension

12.3 Horror Subgenre Timer Templates

12.3.1 Cosmic Horror Timers

1. **Dread Clock** (10 segments) - Personal psychological deterioration
2. **Reality Fracture Clock** (12 segments) - Fundamental laws of reality becoming unreliable
3. **Collective Sanity Clock** (8 segments) - Group psychological effects and shared hallucinations
4. **Existential Threat Clock** (15 segments) - Cosmic entity approaching full manifestation

12.3.2 Haunted Location Timers

1. **Dread Clock** (10 segments) - Personal psychological deterioration
2. **Location Corruption Clock** (10 segments) - Physical space becoming more hostile/supernatural
3. **Resident Sanity Clock** (8 segments) - Other inhabitants becoming affected
4. **Supernatural Escalation Clock** (12 segments) - Ghostly activity intensifying

12.3.3 Isolated Institution Timers

1. **Dread Clock** (10 segments) - Personal psychological deterioration
2. **Sanity Decay Clock** (8 segments) - Overall mental health of group deteriorating
3. **Institution Collapse Clock** (10 segments) - Social/order breakdown of location
4. **Horror Manifestation Clock** (12 segments) - Threat becoming more active/visible

12.3.4 Body Horror Timers

1. **Dread Clock** (10 segments) - Personal psychological deterioration
2. **Physical Corruption Clock** (8 segments) - Character's body becoming affected
3. **Social Isolation Clock** (6 segments) - Relationships breaking down due to transformation
4. **Transformation Completion Clock** (10 segments) - Full metamorphosis approaching

12.4 Timer Advancement Trigger Generator

12.4.1 Dread Timer Triggers (Personal Psychological Effects)

- **Mild (1 segment):** Unsettling sounds/sights, minor paranoia, sleep disturbances
- **Moderate (2 segments):** Witnessing supernatural events, personal failure, disturbing revelations

- **Severe (3 segments):** Companion harmed/lost, direct entity contact, moral compromise

12.4.2 Reality Fracture Triggers (Cosmic Horror)

- **Mild (+1):** Impossible stellar movements, minor geometric anomalies, temporal glitches
- **Moderate (+2):** Dimensional mathematics researched, witness alien geometry, reality instability incidents
- **Severe (+3):** Ancient experiments disturbed, fundamental laws becoming unreliable, entity partially manifesting

12.4.3 Location Corruption Triggers (Haunted/Supernatural)

- **Mild (+1):** Temperature drops, unexplained sounds, objects moving
- **Moderate (+2):** Physical manifestations, apparitions becoming more aggressive, structural damage
- **Severe (+3):** Laws of physics breaking down, location becoming sentient, permanent alterations

12.4.4 Institution Collapse Triggers (Isolated Settings)

- **Mild (+1):** Communication failures, supply shortages, minor conflicts
- **Moderate (+2):** Authority figures becoming erratic, services failing, infighting
- **Severe (+3):** Complete breakdown of order, mass hysteria, leadership collapse

12.5 Timer Consequence Generator

12.5.1 When Dread Timer Fills (10 segments):

- Character becomes Broken: Out of control, may become hostile, permanent psychological damage
- Party suffers -2 dice to all social rolls due to collective tension
- Reality begins to reflect character's mental state (shared hallucinations)

12.5.2 When Reality Fracture Timer Fills (12 segments):

- Barriers between dimensions collapse completely
- Entity manifests fully in normal space
- Local reality becomes permanently unreliable (ongoing 2 SB per scene)

12.5.3 When Collective Sanity Timer Fills (8 segments):

- Shared hallucinations become indistinguishable from reality
- Party begins to exist partially outside normal space
- Group paranoia leads to infighting (start all social rolls Desperate)

12.5.4 When Existential Threat Timer Fills (15 segments):

- Entity begins reshaping local reality according to alien logic
- PCs must make Spirit + Resolve (DV 6) or gain permanent corruption
- Campaign enters final phase - immediate resolution required

12.6 Mixed Horror Generator System

12.6.1 Procedure:

1. **Select Base Horror Subgenre:** Choose primary horror theme
2. **Draw Base Timers:** Use template for that subgenre
3. **Add Secondary Elements:** Draw 1-2 cards from different horror subgenres
4. **Blend Consequences:** Merge thematic elements for unique threat
5. **Adjust Timer Sizes:** Modify based on campaign scope and tier

12.6.2 Example Mix - "The Whispering Depths" (Mistlands + Cosmic Horror):

- **Base:** Mistlands haunted location template
- **Add:** Cosmic Horror reality fracture elements
- **Result:** Ancient entities beneath the mist awakening as dimensional barriers weaken
- **Timers:**
 1. Dread Timer (10) - Personal psychological effects
 2. Bell-Line Corruption (8) - Communication system compromised by cosmic influence
 3. Reality Fracture (12) - Local dimensional barriers weakening
 4. Collective Sanity (8) - Mental stability of watch-tower garrison

12.6.3 Mixing Benefits:

- Creates unique, layered threats that feel both local and universal
- Allows for gradual revelation of deeper cosmic implications
- Provides multiple resolution paths (local containment vs. cosmic sealing)
- Maintains personal stakes while expanding to existential consequences

12.7 Quick Setup Cards

12.7.1 Cosmic Horror Quick Setup:

- **Hook:** Stars moving in impossible patterns, reality becoming unreliable
- **Timers:** Dread (10), Reality Fracture (12), Collective Sanity (8), Existential Threat (15)
- **Key Elements:** Alien geometry, temporal distortions, incomprehensible entities

- **Resolution:** Seal dimensional rift, embrace cosmic knowledge, or become heralds of new order

12.7.2 Haunted Location Quick Setup:

- **Hook:** Familiar place becoming hostile, supernatural activity escalating
- **Timers:** Dread (10), Location Corruption (10), Resident Sanity (8), Supernatural Escalation (12)
- **Key Elements:** Ghostly manifestations, location sentience, shared haunting effects
- **Resolution:** Banish spirits, seal location, or join the haunting

12.7.3 Isolated Institution Quick Setup:

- **Hook:** Remote location cut off, internal threat emerging
- **Timers:** Dread (10), Sanity Decay (8), Institution Collapse (10), Horror Manifestation (12)
- **Key Elements:** Social breakdown, confined space tension, group psychology
- **Resolution:** Escape, contain threat, or become part of institution

13 Conclusion

This Horror Campaigns expansion and timer generator system provides GMs with flexible, thematically coherent tools for running horror campaigns of any scope while maintaining the mechanical elegance and player agency that defines Fate's Edge. Whether running a single-session haunted house scenario or an extended cosmic horror campaign, these tools ensure that horror remains personal, consequential, and mechanically integrated with the core Fate's Edge experience.

Remember that the best horror emerges from player investment in their characters and the world around them. Use these mechanical tools to support narrative tension and emotional investment, not replace them. The fear of what might be lurking in the shadows is often more effective than showing every monster in detail, and the psychological consequences of player choices should feel meaningful and lasting.

In the spaces between certainty and chaos, in the whispers of the unknown, and in the breaking points of human endurance, the truth waits patiently. Will you listen? Will you pay the price? Will you survive to tell the tale?

— Baron Quentin Asselin, Keeper of the Chained Angel's archives
Tarlington, in the hour before the ninth bell (which never rings for the living)

*Annotated and prepared for publication by Lerris Fenwood, with the assistance of the Grey Wanderer.
The ninth cup remains un-poured. The ninth bell has not rung. The ledger does not close.*